

ONE THING LED TO ANOTHER

“How did you end up here?”

It sounds like a simple question until you try to answer it properly.

Not here as in this chair, this job, this town, this particular Tuesday with three dollars in your account and a fuel light you’ve been ignoring since yesterday. Here as in the life you’re standing in now. The people still beside you. The ones who aren’t. The work you stayed with, the place you left, the number you still recognise even though you deleted the name years ago.

The easy answer is that one thing led to another.

Which is true. It’s also fairly useless.

One thing always leads to another. The difficult part is working out which things mattered. At the time, they rarely announce themselves. There’s no shift in the lighting when you make a decision that will follow you for years. No ominous music when you hand someone your keys, accept the lift, take the job, stay for one more drink or decide not to make the phone call. Usually, it’s just an ordinary day continuing to behave like one.

You don’t know that something is a beginning while you’re standing in it. It might look like a spare mattress, a borrowed uniform, a half-packed bag or a name written on the back of a receipt because neither of you has your phone handy. Beginnings are inconsiderate like that. They arrive looking like nothing much, then expect to be recognised years later when half the details have gone missing.

Endings are not always more helpful. Some make themselves obvious. There’s shouting, a door closes, someone drives away. Others happen so quietly that you carry on for months without realising something has already finished. You keep an old key on the ring. Leave a number in your phone. Tell people you’ll go back when things settle down, as though life has ever shown the slightest interest in settling down for your convenience.

Later, you make a story from what remains.

You choose the parts that still make sense. Leave out the names that require too much explanation. Move quickly over the years when nothing seemed to change, even though you now understand that plenty was happening underneath. You give certain decisions more thought

than they received at the time. This is generous of you. It allows the person you used to be to appear almost organised.

That person probably appreciates the help.

They had enough to deal with already: getting through the week, covering the rent, waiting for someone to call, hoping someone else wouldn't. Maybe they were trying to hold together a relationship everybody could see was finished. Maybe they were telling themselves a job was temporary because admitting they had no better idea felt worse. Maybe they were doing well and still lying awake at two in the morning, convinced they had somehow wandered into another person's life and would be asked to leave as soon as anyone noticed.

Or perhaps they were happy. Properly happy. Those years exist too, although memory can be strangely careless with them. Misery leaves paperwork. Happiness might leave nothing more than an old photograph in which nobody is looking at the camera because whatever was happening beyond the frame seemed more important.

The person you were then couldn't see any of this.

They didn't know which friendships would survive distance, money, children, grief or the slow administrative murder of trying to organise a catch-up between adults. They couldn't know which humiliation would still make them sweat twenty years later, or which apparent disaster would eventually become a story told so often that somebody else could finish it. They had no idea that a sentence spoken without much thought might remain in another person's head long after they had forgotten saying it.

You know more than they did now. That's the unfair advantage of arriving later.

From here, you can see the turn they missed. You can hear the warning inside a conversation they thought was ordinary. You know who was trying to help, who was full of shit and, if you're being honest, how often those turned out to be the same person. You can identify the moment they should have left and the reason they stayed. You may even understand the person they blamed.

Understanding them doesn't necessarily mean forgiving them. Sometimes the older you looks back with tenderness. Sometimes with embarrassment. Occasionally with the strong desire to reach through time, grab yourself by the shoulders and ask what the fuck you thought you were doing.

The answer, infuriatingly, is that you thought you were doing your best.

Not the best you could imagine now, with years of evidence and the calm intelligence that arrives after the consequences. The best you could manage with what you knew, what you feared, what you wanted and what you were willing to admit. Sometimes that best was decent. Sometimes it was selfish, cowardly or spectacularly stupid. Being able to explain a choice does not make it a good one.

It does make it part of the truth.

Perhaps that is why the shortest answers can feel slightly dishonest even when every word is accurate. They tell people where you went without saying what carried you there. They turn confusion into direction, accidents into decisions and survival into something resembling a plan. They remove the wasted time, the false starts and the years you spent insisting you knew exactly what you were doing.

From far enough away, almost any life can be made to look deliberate.

The fuller account is harder. It asks you to stand beside earlier versions of yourself without letting them rewrite what happened and without punishing them for everything they could not yet know. It asks you to remember that the person making those choices did not think of themselves as your younger self. They were the finished version. You were the one who didn't exist yet.

Maybe something in that feels familiar.

Maybe you have looked around at a life you never planned and tried to identify the single decision responsible, only to find a hundred smaller ones waiting behind it. Maybe there is a person you would need to explain before any of it made sense. Maybe you can't explain it yet. You only know that the straight line other people see was nothing like the route you travelled.

That doesn't make this your story.

But it may be why you recognise the shape of it before you know what happens.

The name attached to the choices from here will be mine. The faces, the places, the damage and whatever came after belong to another life. You are not required to find yourself in any of it. Still, there may be moments when the distance between the person living them and the person looking back feels uncomfortably small.

That is where this story begins.

I know what came next.

The person living it didn't have a fucking clue.